

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

The Government legislates where the phone makers would not, and the Health Bill leaves the Commons

In June the Government gave the technology companies three months to make it impossible for a child to take or share a nude image on a phone. On Tuesday afternoon the three months were up. Lisa Nandy told the House that Apple and Google had made “meaningful changes at operating level” and that “the truth is that they do not meet the scale of this crisis”, and that her officials had that day begun drawing up a Bill to compel what the deadline had not. She put the case in numbers taken from the Internet Watch Foundation and her own Department: 91 per cent of the images are self-generated by children, around 9,000 child sexual abuse offences a year involve an online element, and under-18s are the subject of almost a quarter of online black-mail. Around it the House gave the Health Bill its remaining stages over two long evenings, dividing six times and winning six times, three of them with Labour alone in the No lobby; a Minister explained a weekend of masked protest at Dover and at Portsmouth harbour; and 1,814 written questions were tabled by 223 Members, one of whom asked the same Department six different questions about the same policy and received the same answer six times.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Internet: Age Assurance · Bell Ribeiro-Addy, Labour

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, whether she is planning to use powers under the Online Safety Act to enforce planned minimum age requirements.

THE ANSWER Following the Government's recent consultation, Growing up in the online world, it was announced in June 2026 that government are banning social media companies from offering their services to under-16s. We are aiming for regulations on the social media ban to be laid before Parliament under the powers of the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026 by the end of this year, with the restrictions in effect from Spring 2027.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF

The occupation declared unlawful, and a settlements sanctions regime, Tuesday 8 September. Ed Miliband made a statement on Israel and Palestine that moved the British position. Britain has long called the settlements illegal while staying silent on the occupation as a whole, which the International Court of Justice held unlawful in 2024. The Government's official view is now that the occupation is unlawful too. He announced an import ban on goods from illegal settlements, a new sanctions regime aimed at settlements and their expansion rather than at Israel, a ban on advertising settlements here, and an arms export ban lasting as long as the occupation does. Settlers in the occupied territories have gone from about 270,000 in 1993 to some 770,000.

Protecting children online, Tuesday 8 September. Lisa Nandy told the House of Commons that a three month deadline set for the technology companies in June had not been met, and that she had instructed officials that day to begin drawing up a Bill. Rebecca Paul, the shadow Secretary of State, welcomed it and remembered 16 year old Murray Dowe, who took his own life hours after being tricked into sending an intimate image, then pressed for a date the Secretary of State would not give.

The Health Bill finishes in the Commons, Monday 7 and Tuesday 8 September. Six divisions over two evenings, all won by the Government, and in three of them Labour was alone in the No lobby. The gravest was on Monday night, when a clause requiring the Government to publish its response to the Hughes Report on redress for those harmed by valproate and pelvic mesh within 30 days fell by 170 to 316, and Yvette Cooper moved the Third Reading at 6.51 pm on Tuesday without a division.

Protests at Dover and Portsmouth, Monday 7 September. Sarah Jones, the Minister for Policing and Crime, said around 150 people, many in face coverings, arrived without notice at the port of Dover on Saturday morning, and that on Sunday evening more than 200 protesters gathered at a Portsmouth marina to block three coaches carrying people from a boat of about 120. Officers used a dispersal notice, batons and PAVA spray, and worked until about four in the morning. No arrests were made on either night and investigations continue.

Rough sleeping, bluetongue and the North Sea, Thursday 3 September. Angela Rayner told the House that £442 million has been set aside so that everyone sleeping rough is offered a route off the streets by Christmas, and that closure orders on problem shops will double from six months to twelve. Two urgent questions followed, one on bluetongue, where 795 cases have now been confirmed in Great Britain, and

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Motion to sit in private	1–79
Health Bill, Amendment 1	162–297
Health Bill, New Clause 145	170–316
Representation of the People Bill, New Clause 65	166–346
Health Bill, New Clause 143	106–302
Health Bill, New Clause 140	79–300
Health Bill, New Clause 6	77–317
Health Bill, New Clause 142	108–357
Representation of the People Bill, New Clause 67	105–410
Representation of the People Bill, Third Reading	411–102
Representation of the People Bill, New Clause 88	85–427

one from Andrew Bowie on the Jackdaw and Rosebank oil fields, which was answered again in the House of Lords on Monday.

Value added tax comes off electricity bills, Wednesday 9 September. At Prime Minister's Questions, Andy Burnham told the House: I will remove VAT from electricity bills next month. He added that it would not solve everything but would take a little pressure off, told the questioner to look out for further measures through the year, and announced a two pound cap on bus fares across England for the whole of 2027, noting that the fares cap does not apply in Scotland. He put both under one description, that this is a cost of living Government. Westminster Hall spent the day on public confidence in the police.

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health	242
Housing	209
Home Office	156
Environment	150
Treasury	143
Transport	133
Defence	119
Justice	111
14 others	551

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

11 Mental Health Services · 10 Gold and Foreign Exchange Reserves · 9 Honduras: Bilateral Aid · 7 Members: Correspondence · 7 Vehicle Number Plates · 7 Frimley Park Hospital · 6 Advice and Guidance Services · 6 Chagos Islands: Sovereignty · 6 Game: Birds · 6 Neurological Diseases: Health Services

THE FEATURE

Six questions, one answer, six times

Dr Luke Evans shadowed health for twenty-one months. On 31 August he was moved to energy. In the first sitting week of the new brief he tabled fifty-eight written questions, twenty-six of them to the department he had just left and none at all to the one he had just joined. Six of them went to a single subject, the pathway by which a family doctor seeks specialist advice instead of making a referral. Each cited a different published finding. The Royal College of Physicians found that 89% of the doctors giving that advice have had no formal training for it and that 47% have no time set aside for it. The magazine Pulse found that family doctors believe 36% of unsolicited replies ask them to do work outside their remit. The Health Services Safety Investigations Body found that badly run versions of the pathway have contributed to delayed and missed diagnoses, and recommended a rapid evaluation. On 8 September the Minister for Secondary Care, Karin Smyth, answered all six. The six answers are word for word identical. None of them names the Royal College of Physicians, or Pulse, or the Health Services Safety Investigations Body, and none says whether the recommendation is accepted. That same evening the Minister carried the Health Bill through its final Commons stages, and the House voted by 162 to 297 to keep the clause that abolishes the very body whose findings the questions cited.

THE MOST ACTIVE

Mike Wood asked more written questions than any other Member of Parliament this week with 95.

Luke Pollard answered the most with 525.